Experiment 7: Layout Trials and Aesthetic Evaluation in GIMP

1. Aim

To design multiple mobile app layout variations using **GIMP**, trialing different color schemes and interface structures to evaluate their impact on aesthetics, readability, and overall usability based on user feedback.

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2. Technical Methodology

The experiment utilized the GNU Image Manipulation Program (GIMP) to simulate a high-fidelity mobile login interface.

- **Layer Management:** As shown in the design interface, each UI component (e.g., Login_Button, SSO_Group) was assigned to distinct named layers. This allows for granular control over individual elements without affecting the entire composition.
- **Color Variation:** The **Colorize Tool** and **Bucket Fill** were used to rapidly pivot between themes, such as the Blue (Layout 1), Pink (Layout 2), and Teal (Layout 3) variants.
- **Visual Elements:** Standard mobile components were created using the **Rectangle Select Tool** for input fields and the **Text Tool** for headings and SSO (Single Sign-On) labels.

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3. Comparative User Feedback

Layout	Aesthetic Profile	Usability/Readability Observations
Layout 1 (Blue)	Simple and bold.	Lacked sufficient color contrast; users requested better button styling (shadows/depth).
Layout 2 (Pink)	Vibrant and hierarchical.	Spacing was perceived as "tight," leading to a cluttered feel.
Layout 3 (Teal)	Minimalist and professional.	**Best performance:** Consistent spacing and a balanced color scheme resulted in high satisfaction.

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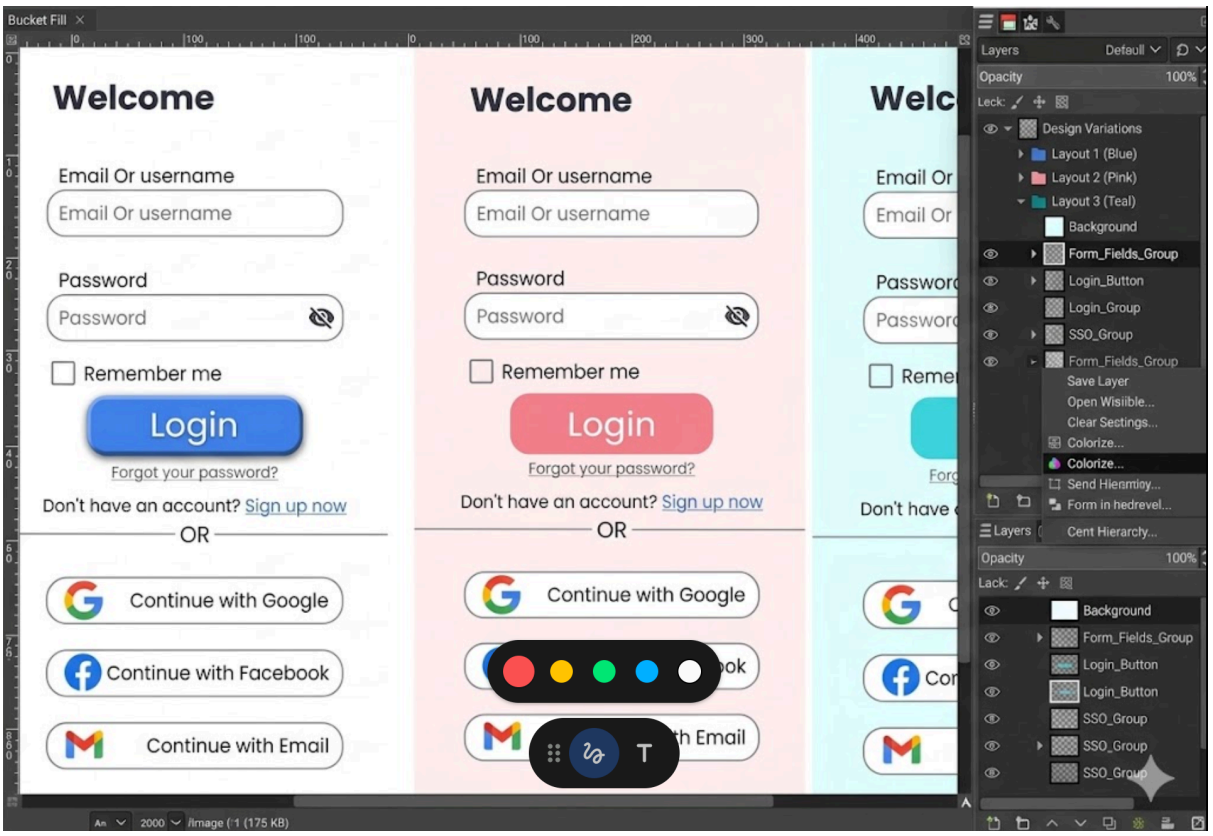
4. Observation

- **Impact of Spacing:** The transition from Layout 2 to Layout 3 highlights that **white space** (negative space) is as critical as color for usability. Increased spacing reduced the perception of clutter and improved focus.
- **Color Psychology:** Users gravitated toward Layout 3's teal palette, suggesting it provided a more "professional" and "clean" aesthetic compared to the vibrant pink of Layout 2.
- **Affordance:** Feedback on Layout 1 regarding "button styling" indicates that users expect visual cues (like depth or shadows) to understand that an element is interactive.
- **SSO Integration:** The consistent placement of Google, Facebook, and Email "Continue with..." buttons across all layouts maintained a familiar mental model for the users.



5. Result

The experiment identified **Layout 3** as the preferred design due to its modern look and excellent usability. By iterating through the GIMP project layers, adjustments were made to spacing and contrast to reach a final refined design that balanced functional requirements with aesthetic appeal.

6. Conclusion

Aesthetic choices in UI design significantly influence user perception of usability. This experiment demonstrates that even minor adjustments in color contrast and section spacing can lead to substantial improvements in user satisfaction. Utilizing GIMP for layout trials

allows designers to refine these details effectively before moving into the final development phase.